

User Guide & FAQ

Every feature of the US Tape Time Tracking Application, step by step, for employees, managers and admins, plus plain-English answers to every error message.

Audience	US Tape employees, shift managers, admins, and IT staff supporting them
Applies to	Branch main at commit 78483ab (28 September 2026)
Screenshots	Taken from the real application running against sample data. Names, emails and PINs shown are fictional
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Companion docs	XAMPP Hosting Guide, Git & Version Control Guide, README.md

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1. Overview

The Time Tracking Application replaces paper time cards. Employees punch in and out at a shared kiosk with a personal 5-digit PIN. Managers check those punches, fix mistakes, approve shifts, add notes and export hours to Excel for payroll. Admins manage who has access.

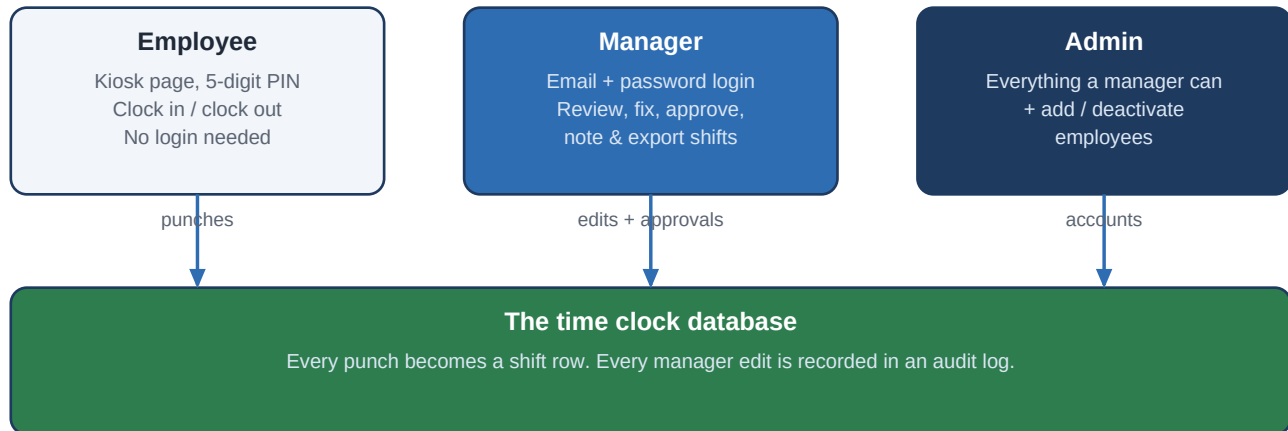


Figure 1: Who uses what.

Task	Employee	Manager	Admin	Section
Clock in / clock out with a PIN	Yes	Yes	Yes	3
Sign in to the manager pages	No	Yes	Yes	4
Search employees, view and filter shifts	No	Yes	Yes	5
Correct clock-in / clock-out times	No	Yes	Yes	6
Approve shifts, add shift notes	No	Yes	Yes	6
Export hours to Excel (all, selected, or one employee)	No	Yes	Yes	7
Add employees, assign PINs, activate / deactivate	No	No	Yes	8

1.1 A normal pay period, start to finish

1. **Admin** adds each employee once and gives them their PIN (Section 8).
2. **Employees** punch in when they arrive and out when they leave, every shift (Section 3).
3. **Manager**, daily or weekly: opens each employee's shifts, fixes missed or wrong punches, adds a note explaining any change, and ticks **Approved** (Sections 5–6).
4. **Manager**, at the end of the pay period: sets the date range and exports to Excel (Section 7). The file has every shift plus a total-hours line per employee.
5. **Admin**, when someone leaves: deactivates their account so their PIN stops working.

Before you start: two things everyone should know

- **Times are shown in UTC** (the international standard clock), not US Eastern time. Right now that puts displayed times 4 hours ahead (5 hours in winter), so a 7:00 AM punch shows as 11:00. This is a known issue being fixed. Until then, keep it in mind when reading or typing times.
- **Save one row at a time** on the shift editor. Only the row whose **Save Changes** button you click is saved (Section 6).

2. Getting to the application

The app runs on a computer inside the US Tape network and opens in any web browser (Chrome, Edge, Firefox, Safari). There's nothing to install on your own device.

Page	Address (IT will confirm the server name)	Who
Kiosk (clock in/out)	<code>http://SERVER-NAME/timeclock/</code>	Everyone
Manager sign-in	<code>http://SERVER-NAME/timeclock/manager_login.php</code> or the Manager Sign In button on the kiosk	Managers, admins

It only works on the company network. From home or on mobile data, the page won't load. That is intentional (see the XAMPP guide).

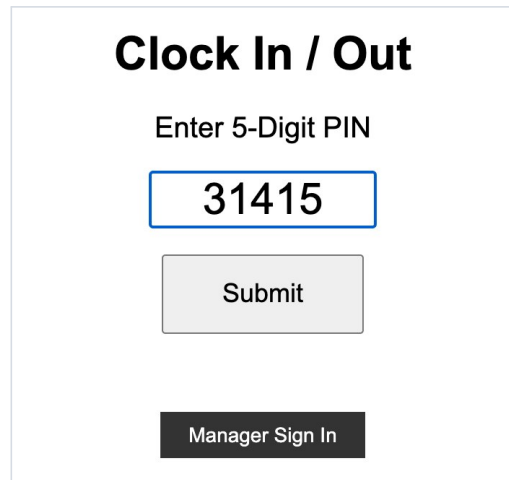
First-time setup (installing the server, creating the database and the first admin) is an IT task covered in the **XAMPP Hosting Guide** and the README.

3. Employees: clocking in and out

You only need your **5-digit PIN**. The same PIN and the same button are used to clock in and to clock out: the system knows which one you need.

3.1 Clock in

1. Go to the kiosk. You'll see **Clock In / Out** and a PIN box.
2. Type your 5-digit PIN. Include any leading zeros: PIN 03323 must be typed as all five digits.
3. Press **Submit** (or Enter).



Clock In / Out

Enter 5-Digit PIN

31415

Submit

Manager Sign In

The kiosk with a PIN typed in.

You'll see **Clocked IN successfully**. After 3 seconds the page goes back to the keypad for the next person.



Clocked IN successfully.

Redirecting...

Confirmation after clocking in.

3.2 Clock out

At the end of your shift, do exactly the same thing: type your PIN, press Submit. Because you already have an open shift, this time you'll see **Clocked OUT successfully**.



Clocked OUT successfully.

Redirecting...

Confirmation after clocking out.

Always read the message

The message tells you which punch happened. If you meant to clock in but it says **Clocked OUT**, you were still clocked in from before (maybe you forgot to clock out last time). Tell your manager so they can fix both shifts.

3.3 Rules and tips

- **Don't press Submit twice.** A second punch right after the first clocks you straight back out (or in).
- **Breaks:** the system records one continuous shift per clock-in. Follow your supervisor's instructions on whether to punch out for breaks.
- **Keep your PIN private.** Anyone who knows it can punch for you, and every punch is recorded with the device's network address.

- **Forgot to clock in or out?** Tell your manager as soon as possible. They can correct the time and add a note (Section 6).
- **Seeing your hours:** employees can't view their hours in the app yet. Ask your manager, who can export them.

3.4 If something goes wrong at the kiosk

You see	What it means	What to do
Invalid PIN.	No active employee has that PIN. Either it was mistyped, or your account has been deactivated	Retype it carefully. If it still fails, ask a manager or admin to check your account
A pop-up saying Please match the requested format (or the box turns red)	You typed fewer than 5 digits, or letters	Type exactly 5 numbers
Invalid PIN format.	The PIN wasn't 5 digits (rare, usually a browser problem)	Go back and retype the PIN
Page won't load	The device isn't on the company network, or the server is off	Tell a manager, who will contact IT. Write your times down so they can be entered later
DB Connection failed ...	The server's database isn't running	Tell a manager / IT (IT: XAMPP guide Section 9)

Invalid PIN.

What a wrong PIN looks like.

4. Managers: signing in

1. On the kiosk page click **Manager Sign In** (bottom of the page), or go straight to the manager sign-in address.
2. Enter your **email** and **password** exactly as your admin set them up. The password is case-sensitive.
3. Click **Login**. You'll land on the **Manager Dashboard**.

Manager Login

Email

Password

Login

Manager sign-in page.

You see	Why	What to do
Invalid credentials.	Wrong email or password, <i>or</i> your account is deactivated, <i>or</i> no password has been set for you	Check spelling and Caps Lock. If it still fails, ask an admin to check your account
Access denied. (red, on the sign-in page)	Your email and password are right, but your role is <i>Employee</i> , which can't use manager pages	Ask an admin to change your role to Manager if you need access
Plain page saying only Access denied.	You opened a manager page without signing in, or your session expired after about 24 minutes of inactivity	Go to the sign-in page and log in again

Manager Login

Invalid credentials.

A failed sign-in.

Signing out

There is no Sign Out button yet (it's on the improvement list). On a shared computer, **close the browser completely** when you finish. Otherwise the next person can use your manager session until it times out.

5. Managers: the dashboard

The dashboard lists every **active** employee, alphabetically by first name. From here you open anyone's shifts, search, and export.

Manager Dashboard

[Back to Employee Clock-In](#)
[Employee Management](#)
[Export Selected to Excel](#)

Check specific employees below to export just them — your checks are kept even if you search for someone else first. Leave everyone unchecked to export the full filtered list.

No employees selected yet — export will include everyone in the filtered list. [Clear Selection](#)

From: To: Search Employee: [Filter](#)

☐	Employee	Email	View Shifts
☐	Alex Admin	admin@ustape.local	View Shifts
☐	Jordan Lee	jordan.lee@ustape.local	View Shifts
☐	Morgan Manager	manager@ustape.local	View Shifts
☐	Priya Patel	priya.patel@ustape.local	View Shifts
☐	Sam Rivera	sam.rivera@ustape.local	View Shifts
☐	Taylor Brooks	taylor.brooks@ustape.local	View Shifts

Manager Dashboard as an admin sees it.

Part of the page	What it does
Back to Employee Clock-In	Returns to the kiosk page (you stay signed in)
Employee Management	Opens the admin page. Only admins see this button
Export Selected to Excel	Downloads shifts for the ticked employees, or everyone in the list if nobody is ticked (Section 7)
Clear Selection	Unticks everyone you've selected for export
From / To	Date range used by Export . It doesn't change who appears in the list. Default: the last 7 days
Search Employee + Filter	Shows only employees whose name contains what you type (e.g. pat finds Priya Patel)
Tick boxes	Choose specific employees to export. The box in the header ticks everyone shown
View Shifts	Opens that employee's shift list (Section 6)

A **Manager** (not admin) sees the same page without the Employee Management button:

Manager Dashboard

[Back to Employee Clock-In](#)[Export Selected to Excel](#)

Check specific employees below to export just them — your checks are kept even if you search for someone else first. Leave everyone unchecked to export the full filtered list.

No employees selected yet — export will include everyone in the filtered list. [Clear Selection](#)

From: To: Search Employee: [Filter](#)

☐	Employee	Email	View Shifts
☐	Alex Admin	admin@ustape.local	View Shifts
☐	Jordan Lee	jordan.lee@ustape.local	View Shifts
☐	Morgan Manager	manager@ustape.local	View Shifts
☐	Priya Patel	priya.patel@ustape.local	View Shifts
☐	Sam Rivera	sam.rivera@ustape.local	View Shifts
☐	Taylor Brooks	taylor.brooks@ustape.local	View Shifts

Manager Dashboard as a regular manager sees it.

6. Managers: reviewing, correcting and approving shifts

Click **View Shifts** next to an employee. The page lists their shifts, newest first, for the chosen date range.

Priya Patel - Shifts

Export to Excel

Edit times in a simple format: YYYY-MM-DD HH:MM (example: 2026-04-21 08:30)

From

09/21/2026

To

09/28/2026

Apply Time Range

Total Hours in Selected Range: 32.33

Clock In	Clock Out	Approved	Edited	Note	Action
2026-09-25 12:10 Example: 2026-04-21 08:30	2026-09-25 20:15 Leave blank for open shift	☐	Original	e.g. late, left early	Save Changes
2026-09-24 12:05 Example: 2026-04-21 08:30	2026-09-24 20:05 Leave blank for open shift	☒	Original	left early - appointment	Save Changes
2026-09-23 12:05 Example: 2026-04-21 08:30	2026-09-23 20:05 Leave blank for open shift	☒	Original	e.g. late, left early	Save Changes
2026-09-22 11:05 Example: 2026-04-21 08:30	2026-09-22 19:20 Leave blank for open shift	☒	Original	e.g. late, left early	Save Changes

Back to Manager Dashboard

An employee's shifts, with one note already added.

6.1 Pick the date range

1. Set **From** and **To** (defaults to the last 7 days, including today).
2. Click **Apply Time Range**.
3. **Total Hours in Selected Range** updates. It includes a shift that's still open, counted up to right now.

6.2 Read each row

Column	Meaning
Clock In / Clock Out	When the shift started and ended (shown in UTC, see Section 1). An empty Clock Out means the employee is still clocked in
Approved	Ticked = a manager has signed off on this shift for payroll
Edited	Original (green) = exactly as punched. Edited (amber) = a manager has saved changes to this shift at least once
Note	Free-text comment from a manager, up to 255 characters, e.g. "late", "left early - appointment", "forgot to clock out - fixed"
Save Changes	Saves this row only

6.3 Correct a time

1. Click in the Clock In or Clock Out box and type the correct time in the format YYYY-MM-DD HH:MM using the 24-hour clock, e.g. 2026-09-24 20:05 for 8:05 PM. Remember the times are UTC.
2. Add a **Note** explaining the change (strongly recommended: payroll and auditors will see it).
3. Click **Save Changes** on that same row. The page reloads, and the row now shows **Edited**.

6.4 Approve a shift

Tick **Approved** on the row, then click that row's **Save Changes**. To un-approve, untick and save. Approving also marks the row **Edited**, because any save does.

6.5 Add or change a note

Type in the **Note** box and click that row's **Save Changes**. To remove a note, clear the box and save. Notes also appear in the Excel export.

Important: save each row separately

- If you change three rows and click Save on one of them, **only that one is saved**. The other two are silently lost when the page reloads. Change a row, save it, then move on.
- **You can't save a shift that's still open** (empty Clock Out). Doing so shows an error page with *Incorrect datetime value*. Nothing is damaged: go back, then either wait until the employee clocks out, or type a Clock Out time before saving.
- **Check the times make sense** before saving. The app doesn't yet stop you saving a clock-out earlier than the clock-in, which gives negative hours.

6.6 What gets recorded

Every save writes an entry to the **audit log**: which shift, who saved it, the old and new clock-in, clock-out, approval and note, and when. Managers can't see or change the audit log in the app. IT can read it in phpMyAdmin (table AUDIT_LOG) if a change ever needs to be investigated.

To leave, click **Back to Manager Dashboard**.

7. Managers: exporting to Excel

Exports download as a .csv file, which opens directly in Excel. The file name shows the date range, e.g. shifts_2026-09-21_to_2026-09-28.csv. It is saved to your browser's Downloads folder.

7.1 Three ways to export

You want	Do this
Everyone	Dashboard → set From/To → Filter → make sure nobody is ticked (click Clear Selection) → Export Selected to Excel
Specific people	Dashboard → set From/To → Filter → tick the employees → Export Selected to Excel . You can search for one person, tick them, search for another, tick them too: your ticks are remembered
Everyone matching a search	Type in Search Employee → Filter → nobody ticked → Export Selected to Excel
One employee	Open their View Shifts page → set the range → Apply Time Range → Export to Excel (top right)

Manager Dashboard

[Back to Employee Clock-In](#)
[Employee Management](#)
[Export Selected to Excel](#)

Check specific employees below to export just them — your checks are kept even if you search for someone else first. Leave everyone unchecked to export the full filtered list.

2 employee(s) selected for export (kept across searches). [Clear Selection](#)

From: To: Search Employee: [Filter](#)

☐	Employee	Email	View Shifts
☐	Alex Admin	admin@ustape.local	View Shifts
☒	Jordan Lee	jordan.lee@ustape.local	View Shifts
☐	Morgan Manager	manager@ustape.local	View Shifts
☒	Priya Patel	priya.patel@ustape.local	View Shifts
☐	Sam Rivera	sam.rivera@ustape.local	View Shifts
☐	Taylor Brooks	taylor.brooks@ustape.local	View Shifts

Two employees ticked for export. The blue line confirms the count.

7.2 How selection works

- Ticks are remembered **in this browser on this computer** (not on the server), even after you search or reload. The line under the buttons says how many are selected.
- If anyone is ticked, the export contains **only the ticked people**, and the search box is ignored.
- Clear Selection** when you're done, or your next export will still use the old ticks.
- The export uses the **From / To dates last applied with Filter**. Change the dates, then click Filter *before* exporting.

7.3 What's in the file

One row per shift, grouped by employee, with a **Total Hours** line and a blank line after each person. Real output from the example above:

Employee	Clock In	Clock Out	Hours	Approved	Note
Jordan Lee	2026-09-22 11:10	2026-09-22 19:10	8	Yes	forgot to clock out - fixed
Jordan Lee	2026-09-23 12:55	2026-09-23 21:00	8.08	Yes	
Jordan Lee	2026-09-25 12:58	2026-09-25 21:13	8.25	No	
Total Hours (Jordan Lee)			32.33		
Priya Patel	2026-09-24 12:05	2026-09-24 20:05	8	Yes	left early - appointment
Total Hours (Priya Patel)			32.33		

(Email and Edited columns and some rows omitted to fit the page.)

- **Hours** are decimal hours: 8.25 = 8 h 15 min, 8.08 ≈ 8 h 5 min.
- A shift still in progress shows **Open** as Clock Out, has no Hours, and is **not** counted in the total.
- The total counts **all** completed shifts in the range, approved or not. Filter on the Approved column in Excel if payroll should only include approved time.
- A file with only the heading row means no shifts matched the dates and people chosen.

8. Admins: managing employees

Admins see an **Employee Management** button on the dashboard. Managers who try to open this page get **Access denied**.

Admin Employee Management

Create employees/admins and activate/deactivate accounts without writing SQL manually.

Add Employee

First Name	
Last Name	
Email	
Role	Select role
PIN (optional)	Auto-generated if blank
Password	
Create Employee	

Existing Employees

Name	Email	Role	PIN	Status	Action
Alex Admin	admin@ustape.local	Admin	10000	Active	Deactivate
Jordan Lee	jordan.lee@ustape.local	Employee	31415	Active	Deactivate
Morgan Manager	manager@ustape.local	Manager	20000	Active	Deactivate
Priya Patel	priya.patel@ustape.local	Employee	27182	Active	Deactivate
Sam Rivera	sam.rivera@ustape.local	Employee	16180	Active	Deactivate
Taylor Brooks	taylor.brooks@ustape.local	Employee	14142	Active	Deactivate

The Employee Management page.

8.1 Add an employee (or manager, or admin)

1. Fill in **First Name**, **Last Name** and **Email**. The email must be unique; it is how managers sign in.
2. Choose a **Role**: **Employee** (kiosk only), **Manager** (manager pages), or **Admin** (manager pages + this page).
3. **PIN (optional)**: leave blank to have a unique 5-digit PIN generated, or type 5 digits of your choice.
4. **Password**: required by the form for every role. It is used only by Managers and Admins to sign in. For regular employees, enter any value. They never use it.

- Click **Create Employee**. A green message shows the assigned PIN. **Write it down and give it to the employee privately.**

Admin Employee Management

Create employees/admins and activate/deactivate accounts without writing SQL manually.

Employee created successfully. Assigned PIN: 03323

Success message with the generated PIN.

8.2 Deactivate or reactivate

- Click **Deactivate** next to someone who has left. Their PIN stops working immediately, they can't sign in, and they disappear from the manager dashboard. **Their past shifts are kept.**
- Click **Activate** to restore them, with the same PIN and password as before.
- You can't deactivate your own account (prevents locking yourself out).
- There is no delete. Deactivating keeps payroll history intact.

8.3 Things this page can't do yet

Changing a name, email, role, PIN or password after creation isn't in the app yet. Ask IT to do it in phpMyAdmin. Example for IT (replace the values):

```
UPDATE EMPLOYEES SET pin = '48213' WHERE email = 'jordan.lee@ustape.local';
UPDATE EMPLOYEES SET password = 'NewPass!9' WHERE email = 'manager@ustape.local';
UPDATE EMPLOYEES SET role_id = 2 /* 1=Employee 2=Manager 3=Admin */ WHERE email = '...';
```

8.4 Admin page messages

Message	Fix
Employee created successfully. Assigned PIN: #####	Done. Give the PIN to the employee
Employee deactivated / activated successfully.	Done
First name, last name, email, and role are required.	Fill in all four
Please provide a valid email address.	Check for typos, e.g. a missing @
An employee with this email already exists.	That person is already set up (they may be deactivated: look for them in the list and click Activate)
PIN must be exactly 5 digits.	Use 5 numbers, or leave it blank for an automatic one
That PIN is already in use.	Choose another, or leave it blank
Password is required for this database setup.	Enter a password (any value for employees)
Selected role does not exist.	Pick a role from the list and try again
You cannot deactivate your own account.	Ask another admin if it really needs doing

Admin Employee Management

Create employees/admins and activate/deactivate accounts without writing SQL manually.

An employee with this email already exists.

Error shown when the email is already used.

9. Frequently asked questions

Employees

Question	Answer
I forgot my PIN.	Ask an admin. They can see it on the Employee Management page.
I clocked in twice by accident and now it says Clocked OUT.	Punch once more to clock back in. The accidental shift is only seconds long, so it adds no real hours. Mention it to your manager so they can add a note.
I forgot to clock out yesterday.	When you next punch it will say Clocked OUT (closing yesterday's shift). Punch again to clock in, and tell your manager so they can fix yesterday's clock-out time.
Can I clock in from my phone?	Only on the company Wi-Fi, using the same address. Your manager may prefer you use the kiosk.
Can I see my hours?	Not in the app yet. Ask your manager for an export.
Does it track where I am?	No. The database has location fields, but the kiosk never sends a location, so they're always empty. It records the network address of the device used.

Managers

Question	Answer
Why do the times look 4–5 hours off?	Times are stored and shown in UTC. Subtract 4 hours (Mar–Nov) or 5 hours (Nov–Mar) for Eastern time. A fix is planned.
I edited several rows but only one changed.	Only the row whose Save Changes you clicked is saved. Re-enter the others and save each one.
Saving gave an error page mentioning <i>Incorrect datetime value</i> .	You saved a shift with an empty Clock Out. Go back; fill in a Clock Out or wait for the employee to clock out.
A shift shows negative hours.	The Clock Out was saved earlier than the Clock In. Open the shift and correct the times.
An employee isn't on the dashboard.	They're deactivated (ask an admin), or a search is active: clear the Search box and click Filter.
My export has the wrong people.	Old ticks are still remembered. Click Clear Selection, then tick again.
My export has the wrong dates.	Change From/To, click Filter , then export.
The export opens as one long column.	Your Excel is set to a different separator. Use Data → From Text/CSV and choose <i>Comma</i> .
Can I delete a shift?	Not in the app. Correct it and note why, or ask IT to remove it in phpMyAdmin (it will still appear in the audit log).
Who changed this shift?	IT can look it up in the AUDIT_LOG table.
The page suddenly says Access denied.	Your session timed out after about 24 minutes idle. Sign in again.
How do I sign out?	Close the browser completely (no Sign Out button yet).

Admins

Question	Answer
How do I reset a manager's password?	Ask IT (Section 8.3). Not possible in the app yet.
Why can't I give a new employee a PIN that starts with 0?	You can: type all 5 digits (e.g. 03323). The employee must type the zero too.
Someone left. Should I delete them?	Deactivate. Deleting would break their shift history and payroll records.
How do I make someone an admin?	Create them with the Admin role. For an existing person, ask IT to change role_id to 3.

10. Error message reference (for IT and power users)

Every message the application can show, where it comes from, and the fix. Anything starting with **Fatal error** or **SQLSTATE** is a technical fault: note what you clicked and pass it to IT.

Message	Page	Cause	Fix
Invalid PIN.	clock_handler.php	PIN not found or employee inactive	Check PIN / activate employee
Invalid PIN format.	clock_handler.php	PIN not 5 digits	Retype
Invalid credentials.	manager_login.php	Wrong email/password, inactive account, or no password set	Check account in admin page / phpMyAdmin
Access denied. (on sign-in form)	manager_login.php	Role is not Manager (2) or Admin (3)	Change role_id
Access denied. (blank page)	dashboard, export, admin	Not signed in, session expired, or a manager opening admin.php	Sign in; admin page needs Admin role
Employee not specified. / Employee not found.	employee_shifts.php	Page opened without a valid employee	Use View Shifts from the dashboard
DB Connection failed: ... [2002]	any	MySQL/MariaDB not running or wrong port	Start MySQL in XAMPP; check config.php port
DB Connection failed: ... [1045] / [1049]	any	Wrong DB user/password / database missing	Fix config.php / create DB (XAMPP guide 6)
Unknown column 'password'	manager_login.php	Database missing the password column	Run the ALTER TABLE in the README
Unknown column 'manager_note'	shifts, export, save	Database created before 15 Sep 2026	ALTER TABLE WORK_TIMES ADD COLUMN manager_note VARCHAR(255) NULL AFTER is_edited;
Incorrect datetime value: "	update_shift.php	Saved an open shift (blank Clock Out)	Known bug. Enter a Clock Out first
Fatal error ... datetime (other text)	update_shift.php	A time wasn't in YYYY-MM-DD HH:MM	Known bug. Go back and retype
Duplicate entry ... for key 'pin'	admin.php	Two PINs generated at the same instant (very rare)	Submit again
Blank white page	any	PHP error with display_errors off	Check Apache error log

Known bugs above are tracked in ISSUES_AND_IMPROVEMENTS.md with the planned fixes.

11. Quick reference cards

Print and post these where they're needed.

EMPLOYEE KIOSK

- 1** Type your 5-digit PIN (include leading zeros)
- 2** Press Submit
- 3** Read the message: Clocked IN or Clocked OUT
- !** Wrong message or Invalid PIN? Tell your manager

MANAGER: WEEKLY REVIEW

- 1** Manager Sign In → email + password
- 2** View Shifts for each employee → set dates → Apply Time Range
- 3** Fix any wrong time (YYYY-MM-DD HH:MM, UTC), add a Note, tick Approved
- 4** Click Save Changes on THAT row, one row at a time
- 5** Dashboard → set dates → Filter → Clear Selection → Export Selected to Excel
- 6** Close the browser when finished

ADMIN: NEW HIRE / LEAVER

- +** Employee Management → fill in details → role → leave PIN blank → any password → Create Employee → give PIN privately
- Employee Management → Deactivate (history is kept; Activate to undo)